

capital COUNTRY

✱ **Harsha Moily, 36**

Project A Rs 1.45-crore microfinance firm with 27,000 customers

Can-do Icon Bill Gates, for the ability to envelop the world with his big idea

The annual global volume of micro-loans has risen from

\$4 bn

in 2001 to

\$25 bn

in 2006



NEW VISION: Moily (right) with a villager in Bagalkot



Photograph courtesy MOKSHA YUG

He could have settled down in London. He had a good job, a family to back his dreams and friends to hook up with. But he left all that to work in India's villages, not giving a handout to the rural poor, but as he says, a leg-up. "We are no micro-credit messiahs," he says, sipping coffee after devouring management guru C.K. Prahalad's theory

on the bottom of the pyramid, "but we would like to join hands with those who don't have the money to make some money out of their skills and resources." Only in this case money doesn't come from a tier fund or a charity but from professional investors who are in it to make their investments profitable.

Three years ago, while visiting home from his office in London—private equity firm Lombardi Odier—he chanced upon the opportunity to log in to the micro-finance sector. Convinced about the rural marketplace, this MBA graduate from Thunderbird School of Global Management, USA, dis-

cussed the idea with his friends and founded his firm Moksha Yug Access in Bagalkot, northwest Karnataka. He wants to treble the number of customers in three years and expand his bouquet to include insurance, retail and lifestyle products. He also hopes to roll in more venture capital firms other than the sole US-based firm that invested Rs 8 crore apart from a high-networth individual.

It has been a new world of opportunities for him and his beneficiaries. "Sakamr from a village in Bagalkot, who bought some cattle from our money, is self-reliant today and plans to buy two more cows in three months. If there is a reason I need to give for leaving a high-profile London office for a make-shift workshop in a dusty village, this is proof enough," he says.

Indeed, as long as there are Sakamr there will be Harsha Moilys.

by Stephen D.

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The market is out there in the rural land, where the real India lives and works.

HARSHA MOILY, Entrepreneur

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